The release of the white paper infuriated China. Zhou publicly objected to the public pressure. National People's Congress standing committee members blamed "Western imperialist forces and their agents in India who wanted to create Sino-Indian conflict" and "change India's foreign policy of peace and neutrality."[49] While Dutt noted that the American press had actually been "very discreet" so as not to complicate things for India, criticism from China that the US was inciting India (and its media) continued.[50]

A September 8 letter from Zhou stating that Nehru had misunderstood his past comments about the McMahon Line only exacerbated the situation. It also laid down a basis for delimitation of the whole border, which India would subsequently dispute. A flabbergasted Nehru was particularly troubled by the Chinese claims in the letter on India's northeast. Indian assessments of China's motivations ranged from Chinese expansionist ambitions to doubts about India's Tibet policy. Overall, a sense developed that Beijing was not trustworthy.

The situation deteriorated that fall and winter. After a major Sino-Indian skirmish in the western sector in October and a Chinese statement seen as threatening to hold India's northeast hostage to concessions in the west, the prime minister's public stance became even firmer. India subsequently rejected China's proposal of mutual withdrawals 20 kilometers from the McMahon Line in the east and from the Line of Actual Control in the west. Policymakers believed that to do so would only strengthen China's position and weaken India's, both on the ground and at the negotiating table. Then China rejected an Indian counteroffer. India considered various proposals to put forth, including a "face-saving" one accepting China's de facto presence in Aksai Chin and a "barter" one that envisioned swapping India's claims in the west with those of China in the east. These ideas went nowhere. Neither did discussions with Zhou in Delhi in April 1960 and three subsequent rounds of discussions between Chinese and Indian officials between June and December. Meanwhile, the lack of trust in China intensified within the government, as did anti-China sentiment outside it.[51]

Watching from Washington

Washington kept a close eye on the situation in Tibet and the border dispute, both of which created an opening for the US.[52] In early 1957, the